

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 10

A Night with a Pompeii Baker

One Ordinary Night of Bread, about 70 CE

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

A map of the bay, an hour-by-hour guide to the baker's night, the real places and people behind the story, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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THE TOWN ON THE RIDGE

Pompeii and the Bay of Naples

Let's begin by finding our way around the bay.



Ancient towns plotted at their real locations on a modern coastline (Natural Earth). The shore has moved since Roman times: Pompeii once stood much nearer the sea.

AT A GLANCE

- A busy town on a low ridge close to the sea, on the Bay of Naples
- Green, vine-covered Vesuvius rising behind it
- Perhaps ten or twelve thousand people
- Our night: about 70 CE, in the reign of Vespasian

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Places you'll visit in the episode

A short, slow tour of the real places behind the story.

Bakery of Modestus · Where 81 round loaves were found inside an oven closed by an iron door; four mills, a stable and a shrine to Vesta.

Bakery of Popidius Priscus · One of the largest in town, with five lava mills still standing beside a great oven.

Hedone's tavern · Where a wall lists prices: one as for wine, two for better, four for Falernian.

The election notices · Painted at night in red letters; one asks the lantern carrier to hold the ladder.

House of Terentius Neo · Home of the famous portrait of a married couple, once called Paquius Proculus.

House of Siricus · Its doorway greets visitors with words meaning, roughly, "welcome, profit".

A painted food bar · Found only a few years ago, with a sea nymph, ducks and a rooster on its counter.

The street fountains · Around forty of them, fed by an aqueduct, a water tower and lead pipes.

The Forum · The great paved square, with the temple of Jupiter at its northern end.

Herculaneum · The neighbouring town, where a loaf stamped with the name of Celer was found.

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A baker's night, hour by hour

Here is the baker's night, one quiet step at a time.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

Sunset	Late evening	Small hours	First light
Shops close	Kneading	Ovens heated	Shutters open

The household in the episode is imagined; the places, tools and bread are real. Times are approximate.

Sunset — Shops close along the street. The last batch of the day comes out, and the oven fire is let down.

Dusk — Two blinkered donkeys begin to turn the hourglass lava mills, grinding Campanian wheat.

Early evening — Flour is sifted: coarse for darker, cheaper bread, fine for white bread, which cost more.

Supper — Cena upstairs: yesterday's bread, puls, olives, cheese, figs, garum and watered wine.

After supper — Bread and salt and a little clay lamp at the lararium, the household shrine.

Late evening — Kneading in the long wooden trough with flour, water, salt and yesterday's leaven.

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Through the night to morning

The town sleeps, and the ovens wake.



Shaping — Each round loaf is scored into eight wedges and pressed with a stamp.

Midnight — The town sleeps. Carts and late drinkers pass; the Forum lies empty under the stars.

Small hours — Fires are stirred back to life in bakery after bakery; the oven is heated for an hour or two.

Before dawn — Embers raked out, floor mopped, loaves slid in on the peel; the iron door is closed.

First light — Golden loaves come out and the shutters open. “The baker is already selling breakfast.”

Morning — Bread goes out across town, and the baker finally sleeps.

Some years later, in 79 CE, Vesuvius buried the town under ash. That is why the mills, ovens and even the loaves are still there to see.

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THE WIDER WORLD

Bread for the Roman world

Now let's step back and see where the grain and the millstones came from.



Approximate extent of the Roman Empire around 100 CE, a generation after the episode, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset.

WHERE THE BREAD BEGAN

- Most of Pompeii's grain came from Campania
- More was shipped in from Sicily, Egypt and North Africa
- More than half of the millstones tested came from near Orvieto

People you'll meet

The real names, and a few imagined ones, that you'll hear along the way.

Secundus & Fortunata · Our imagined baker and his wife, with their children and a young mill boy.

Modestus · Name painted in red near the door of the bakery where the 81 loaves were found.

Popidius Priscus · Owner of one of Pompeii's largest bakeries.

Terentius Neo · Now linked to the house with the famous married couple's portrait.

Celer · Slave of Quintus Granius Verus, named on a loaf stamp from Herculaneum.

Hedone · The woman whose voice speaks in a tavern's price list.

Caecilius Iucundus · Banker whose house held more than 150 wax tablets of business deals.

Umbricius Scaurus · Fish sauce maker whose jars turn up all over town.

Pliny the Elder · Described grades of bread and ways of making it rise.

Martial · Poet who joked that the baker was already selling breakfast.

Apuleius · Wrote of mill donkeys with covered faces.

Vesta · Goddess of the hearth, painted beside a donkey in bakery shrines.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, and what is real

A few small things to listen for, and a note on what is found and what is imagined.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The iron door that closes the oven of Modestus
- Two blinkered donkeys turning the hourglass lava mills
- A round loaf scored into eight wedges and pressed with a stamp
- An election notice asking the lantern carrier to hold the ladder
- The price list on the wall of Hedone's tavern: one as for wine, two for better, four for Falernian

WHAT WE KNOW, AND WHAT WE IMAGINE

The bakeries, mills, ovens, loaves, painted notices and names in this companion are real finds. The baker's household is imagined, drawn from those finds. The bread-counter painting may show an ordinary bread seller or a public handout, and scholars still debate whether Terentius Neo was a baker.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

The Fires of Vesuvius: Pompeii Lost and Found ↗, Mary Beard (Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2010); in the UK, Pompeii: The Life of a Roman Town.

Pompeii and Herculaneum: A Sourcebook ↗, Alison E. Cooley and M. G. L. Cooley (2nd edition, Routledge).

Life and Death in Pompeii and Herculaneum ↗, Paul Roberts (British Museum Press, 2013).

Natural History: A Selection ↗, Pliny the Elder, trans. John F. Healy (Penguin Classics, 1991).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗



An artistic impression made for the episode, not a historical record.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums and places

Museums & places

Pompeii Archaeological Park: the Modestus and Popidius Priscus bakeries, the Forum and the street fountains.

National Archaeological Museum of Naples: the Terentius Neo portrait and the bread-counter painting.

Herculaneum Archaeological Park: the neighbouring town along the bay.

Pompeii in Pictures (online): photographs of almost every house and bakery in the town.





Artistic impressions of round loaves on a shelf and of a lamplit mill room with its domed oven, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Podcasts, and one last thought

Podcasts

The History of Rome, Mike Duncan: the whole story of Rome, told slowly.

Emperors of Rome, Rhiannon Evans and Matt Smith: the rulers of Rome, Vespasian among them.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

At first light, which loaf would you choose: the darker, cheaper bread, or the fine white bread, which cost more?

"The glow of the oven settling into soft red embers, and the long night of bread coming quietly to its end."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE, AND FIND THE NEXT ONE

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙